

United Nations Security Council

Preventing the Militarization of Humanitarian Aid in Conflict Zones

Backgrounder Guide

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Director's Letter

Dear Delegates,

My name is Alveera Wahi, and it is my absolute honour to welcome you to the United Nations Security Council at SPAMUN 2026. I have the utmost pleasure of serving as your Director, alongside our Chair, Minh Dang Tran, and Assistant Director, Aimee Tong. We are incredibly excited to be serving as your dais team for this year's dias team for UNSC at SPAMUN 2026!

The United Nations Security Council holds a unique position within the United Nations and carries the responsibility of responding to some of the most pressing threats to international peace and security. This responsibility becomes especially significant when addressing our topic, Crisis Prevention and Escalation Management in the Taiwan Strait. With competing security interests, military tensions, changing economic environments, and delicate political disagreements at play, this committee will require delegates to look beyond simple solutions and carefully consider the consequences of every action taken.

Throughout the conference, delegates will have the opportunity to navigate the interests of their respective countries while working toward realistic methods of preventing further escalation in the Taiwan Strait. We encourage you to come prepared not only with a strong understanding of your country's foreign policy, but also to enter the room with a willingness to negotiate and adapt to the direction the committee takes. Keep in mind, this committee– which functions as a crisis committee– is shaped by your every decision.

As your dais, we hope to create a committee that is challenging and allows every delegate to contribute meaningfully. Whether this is your first conference or one of many, we strongly encourage you to take risks, speak whenever you can, and make the most of the day.

Position papers are due on October 16th, 10 PM for final submission. Please submit your position papers to unscspamun@southpointe.ca, including your full name and delegation. If you encounter any circumstances that may affect your ability to meet the deadline, please do not hesitate to contact us.

If you have any questions or concerns leading up to the conference, please do not hesitate to reach out through our committee email. On behalf of Minh, Aimee, and me, I am incredibly excited to welcome you to the United Nations Security Council at SPAMUN 2026, and we look forward to meeting you all!

Best,

Alveera Wahi

Director of the United Nations Security Council

SPAMUN 2026

Committee Description

Established in 1945 under the Charter of the United Nations, the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations and holds the primary responsibility of maintaining international peace and security.[1] Unlike most other UN bodies, the Security Council's resolutions can be legally binding on Member States, giving it the most authority in responding to international conflicts and crises.

The Security Council consists of fifteen members. Five of which are referred to as the permanent five: the People's Republic of China, France, the Russian Federation, the United Kingdom, and the United States. The remaining ten seats are held by non-permanent members elected by the General Assembly for two-year terms. Each member holds one vote; however, the five permanent members possess veto power, allowing them to override the passage of a substantive resolution.[2]

The UNSC has several options available when responding to a threat to international peace. These can range from calling for negotiations, ceasefires, imposing sanctions, establishing peacekeeping operations, or, in certain circumstances, authorizing the use of force. However, the Council's ability to act often depends on cooperation between its members, those with and without veto powers.

This becomes especially important in the Taiwan Strait. As China is both directly involved in the dispute and a permanent member of the Security Council, delegates must not only consider what action should be taken but also one they can realistically agree upon. Throughout the committee, delegates will be expected to respond to developments as they occur while preventing a regional confrontation from escalating into a wider international crisis.

[1] https://www.un.org/en/about-us/main-bodies
[2] https://main.un.org/securitycouncil/en/content/voting-system

Topic Overview

The Taiwan Strait, separating the island of Taiwan from the People's Republic of China (PRC), has been one of the most sensitive flashpoints in East Asia for decades. Taiwan has its own government, military, elections, and institutions, but the PRC claims Taiwan as part of its territory and has long insisted that reunification must eventually be achieved. Beijing has also refused to rule out the use of force to achieve this aim[3].

The United States has unofficial relations with Taiwan, and has continued to supply the island with defensive arms,[4] while countries including Japan have increasingly expressed concerns over peace and stability in the Strait[5]. A conflict would also have economic implications well beyond the region, given Taiwan's role in global semiconductor production and as a hub for major trade routes.[6]

For decades, the threat of conflict has been kept in check by a careful balance of deterrence and ambiguity. But tensions over Taiwan have increased, and relations between China and the United States have deteriorated. Aircraft crossings, naval exercises, arms sales, diplomatic visits, and political statements each now have the capacity to elicit larger responses from the other side.

This is an urgent issue for the international community and immediate action is needed. Steps to prevent aggression may be perceived as antagonistic, and steps to prevent escalation may be perceived as weak. Where there are several great military powers operating in close proximity to each other, even an accident or miscalculation has the prospect of escalating into a much bigger confrontation. Therefore, Crisis prevention in the Taiwan Strait relies not only on preventing deliberate conflict but also relies on affirming that smaller incidents do not create one.

[3] https://www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-china-58854081
[4] https://www.cfr.org/task-force-reports/us-taiwan-relations-in-a-new-era/introduction
[5] https://www.csis.org/analysis/escalating-japan-china-tensions-insights-past-and-prospects-future
[6] https://www.researchgate.net/publication/392267228_Semiconductors_and_the_Great_Power_Game_How_Taiwan_Finds_Its_Footing_Amidst_US-China_Tech_Rivalry

Timeline of Events/ Historical Analysis

1949 and the Division Across the Strait

After years of civil war, Mao Zedong's Chinese Communist Party gained control of mainland China and established the People's Republic of China on October 1, 1949.[7] Chiang Kai-shek's Nationalist government, the Republic of China (ROC), retreated to Taiwan. The civil war had effectively produced two governments which claimed to hold China. For years, the ROC continued to occupy China's seat at the United Nations. This changed on October 25, 1971, when the General Assembly adopted Resolution 2758. The resolution recognized the representatives of the People's Republic of China as "the only legitimate representatives of China to the United Nations" and expelled the representatives of Chiang Kai-shek. [8]The PRC consequently assumed China's position at the UN, which included its permanent seat on the Security Council.

Resolution 2758 remains politically important to the Taiwan issue, but delegates should be careful with what the resolution actually establishes. Its text addresses who represents China at the United Nations; it does not explicitly use the word "Taiwan" or provide a detailed settlement of Taiwan's political status. Interpretations of what Resolution 2758 means for Taiwan continue to be disputed internationally.[9]

However, in 1971, Beijing did not begin governing Taiwan. Taiwan continued to maintain its own government and institutions, while the PRC continued to claim sovereignty over the island.

The First Two Taiwan Strait Crises

In September 1954, the PRC began shelling Kinmen, an ROC-controlled group of islands located only a few kilometres from mainland China.[10] Attacks later expanded to other offshore islands.

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[7] https://history.state.gov/milestones/1945-1952/chinese-rev
[8] https://www.ipac.global/campaigns/unra-resolution-2758-factsheet-what-you-need-to-know
[9] ibid
[10] https://history.state.gov/milestones/1953-1960/taiwan-strait-crises

The United States, concerned that the conflict could spread to Taiwan itself, strengthened its support for the ROC and signed a mutual defence treaty with Taipei later that year.[11]

The crisis became serious enough that American officials discussed possibilities that spread from defending the offshore islands to the potential use of nuclear weapons.[12] Fighting ultimately eased in 1955, but only temporarily. Three years later, the PRC again began heavily shelling Kinmen and Matsu. The United States helped the ROC resupply its offshore positions, which placed its forces directly into an already dangerous confrontation.[13] The Second Taiwan Strait Crisis eventually de-escalated without becoming a wider war.

Recognition, the United States and Strategic Ambiguity

Another major shift came in 1979 which was when the United States formally established diplomatic relations with the PRC and ended formal diplomatic relations with Taiwan. Congress simultaneously passed the Taiwan Relations Act,[14] allowing the United States to maintain unofficial relations with Taiwan and continue making defensive arms available to it.

American policy toward a possible cross-strait war has since been associated with what is commonly called "strategic ambiguity".[15] Rather than giving an absolute public guarantee that American forces would defend Taiwan under every circumstance, the United States has historically left some uncertainty around its response.

A guaranteed intervention could deter Beijing, but it could also give leaders in Taipei greater confidence that American forces would support them regardless of their own actions. Saying the United States would not intervene creates the opposite risk, whereas uncertainty attempts to deter both.

The Third Taiwan Strait Crisis

By the 1990s, Taiwan had undergone major political change and was becoming a democracy. Cross-strait tensions rose again in 1995 after Taiwanese President Lee Teng-hui was permitted to visit the United States.[16]

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[11] ibid
[12] ibid
[13] ibid
[14] https://www.brookings.edu/articles/the-taiwan-relations-act/
[15] https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/23477970251335139
[16] ibid

China responded with missile tests and military exercises near Taiwan. As tensions continued into 1996, the United States deployed two aircraft carrier battle groups to waters near Taiwan.[17] Both sides utilized military signalling, however, no combat preceded. That fact can make the Third Taiwan Strait Crisis look successful in hindsight: pressure was applied and deterrence held, which eventually led to the end of the immediate crisis. Yet the same sequence could have produced a very different result.

August 2022

On August 2, 2022, Speaker of the United States House of Representatives Nancy Pelosi arrived in Taiwan. Beijing had publicly warned against the visit beforehand. Following her arrival, China announced large-scale military exercises in several zones surrounding Taiwan. The People's Liberation Army conducted live-fire exercises involving naval and air forces and launched ballistic missiles around the island.[18][19]

Chinese forces operated around several sides of Taiwan, while military aircraft increasingly crossed the median line of the Taiwan Strait. This was an unofficial boundary that had long helped reduce encounters between forces from the two sides; being crossed led to heightened fears of confrontation. There was still no declared war, as Commercial ships still crossed the region and the governments continued to communicate. But by this point, the difference between a demonstration of force and preparation for something larger was becoming increasingly difficult to read.

For this committee, the timeline concludes in August 2022. Events occurring beyond this point are not predetermined by real-world history and will instead develop in response to the actions taken throughout the committee.

Current Situation

[17] https://www.jstor.org/stable/4464300:8

[18] https://www.reuters.com/world/asia-pacific/pelosi-expected-arrive-taiwan-tuesday-sources-say-2022-08-02/

[19] https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/2022/08/02/nancy-pelosi-taiwan-visit/

On August 2, 2022, Speaker of the United States House of Representatives Nancy Pelosi landed in Taipei and became the highest-ranking American official to visit Taiwan in twenty-five years.[20] Beijing had constantly warned against the visit, as it argued that it violated China's sovereignty and sent the wrong signal regarding Taiwanese independence.

Within hours, the People's Liberation Army (PLA) announced a series of large-scale exercises in six areas surrounding Taiwan. Beginning on August 4, the exercises included naval deployments, aircraft operations, live-fire training, and ballistic missile launches.[21] Several exercise zones surrounded major Taiwanese ports and extended closer to the island than during previous crises, swiftly raising concerns amongst the international community that the operations could resemble the early stages of a blockade.[22] Taiwan placed its military on heightened alert but avoided directly confronting Chinese forces.

The crisis was no longer contained to China and Taiwan. On August 4, Japan's Ministry of Defense assessed that China had launched nine ballistic missiles, of which five landed within Japan's Exclusive Economic Zone. The United States maintained military forces in the wider region while stating that it would continue operating in "accordance with international law".

Commercial vessels continue to travel through the region, diplomatic channels remain open, and neither Beijing nor Taipei has announced an intention to begin armed conflict. This leaves governments with a difficult distinction to make: whether China's actions remain a temporary demonstration of force or represent the beginning of a new military reality surrounding Taiwan.

The distinction matters because responding too aggressively carries its own risk. Additional foreign military deployments could deter further Chinese action, but Beijing could interpret the same deployments as preparation for intervention. Doing nothing may avoid immediate confrontation, but in the meantime, this would allow increasingly large military operations around Taiwan to become normal.

The Security Council therefore meets without knowing what comes next. China remains both a direct party to the crisis and a permanent member of the Council with veto power. The United States, another veto power, also maintains unofficial relations with Taiwan and remains its primary supplier of defensive arms. Delegates enter committee at this point. The military exercises are ongoing; forces from several states are present within the region as aforementioned, and a single collision, missile miscalculation, political decision, or misunderstood move could change the nature of the crisis.

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[20] https://www.cbc.ca/news/world/pelosi-taiwan-china-1.6539545

[21] https://www.scmp.com/news/china/military/article/3366011/mainland-china-stepping-preparations-taiwan-blockade-report-says

[22] https://www.lawfaremedia.org/article/water-wars-speaker-pelosis-taiwan-visit-ignites-us-china-tensions

From this moment onward, events in committee do not follow the historical timeline. Decisions made by delegates will determine whether the confrontation de-escalates or develops into a wider conflict.

Bloc Positions

China and States Emphasizing Sovereignty

The People's Republic of China maintains the strongest position within this bloc. Beijing considers Taiwan an inseparable part of China and opposes any action that it views as supporting Taiwanese independence or interfering in China's internal affairs. The PRC's 2005 Anti-Secession Law also states that China may use "non-peaceful means" under certain circumstances if possibilities for peaceful reunification are exhausted.[23]

Within the Security Council, China is likely to oppose resolutions that characterize Taiwan as an independent state or authorize international involvement against Beijing's wishes. Its veto power makes this particularly important. Russia has also generally supported China's position on the Taiwan issue and has publicly reaffirmed its support for the One-China principle.

Other states may not support every Chinese military action but still share Beijing's concern over sovereignty and non-interference. For these delegates, preventing escalation may mean limiting outside involvement rather than increasing it.

United States and Security Partners

American policy has historically attempted to deter both a forced change to the status quo by Beijing and unilateral actions that could provoke conflict. In a crisis, the United States may therefore support measures intended to reduce Chinese military pressure while preserving its ability to assist Taiwan.

Several American allies and partners share concerns over stability in the Taiwan Strait, although this does not mean they would automatically support military intervention. Japan has a particularly direct interest. Its southwestern islands sit close to Taiwan, American forces are

[23] https://www.mac.gov.tw/en/News_Content.aspx?n=8A319E37A32E01EA&sms=2413CFE1BCE87E0E&s=D1B0D66D5788F2D, E

stationed throughout Japan, and during the August 2022 exercises Japan assessed that five Chinese ballistic missiles landed within its Exclusive Economic Zone.[24]

States Prioritizing De-escalation and Non-Interference

Many maintain important economic relations with China while also depending on a stable Indo-Pacific for trade and security. Rather than choosing between Beijing and Washington these states are more likely to emphasize de-escalation, peaceful dialogue, sovereignty, and restraint from all parties. This position is especially relevant for states that traditionally place considerable importance on the principle of non-interference. For states such as these, an expanded American military presence may be concerning without making Chinese military escalation acceptable either.

These delegates could become particularly influential in the Security Council. With China capable of vetoing action directed against it, combined with the United States' stubbornness to accept measures it views as weakening Taiwan's security, proposals focused on communication, temporary military restraint, or other confidence-building measures may have a greater chance of gaining support. Neutrality, however, becomes harder to maintain as a crisis escalates.

Discussion Questions

1. At what point does a military exercise become a threat to international peace and security?
2. How can the Security Council discourage further military escalation without provoking the escalation it is attempting to prevent?
3. What actions can the Security Council realistically take when a permanent member is directly involved in the crisis?
4. How should the international community respond if military exercises begin to restrict commercial access to Taiwan?

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[24] https://www.reuters.com/world/asia-pacific/japan-protests-after-chinese-missiles-land-its-exclusive-economic-zone-2022-08-04, /

5. What role should the United States and other regional military powers play in preventing conflict?
6. How can communication between opposing militaries be maintained during periods of heightened tension?
7. Should economic sanctions be considered before armed conflict has occurred, and if so, what consequences could they create?
8. How should the Security Council respond to an accidental collision, missile strike, or other incident if responsibility is initially unclear?
9. To what extent should Taiwan's position be considered within the Security Council despite its lack of representation in the United Nations?
10. What actions can states take to deter aggression without making their opponents believe an attack is imminent?

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